

How to Run Android Without Google

You can liberate your Android device from the clutches of Google and take charge of it completely! Remember the old adage that nothing comes for free? Well, although Android is mostly free, there is plenty of Google's bits and the manufacturer's own software locked up in it. You can almost free yourself and your device from Google by carefully reading this article and implementing its suggestions.

If you are dependent on Google apps or if you need to regularly pull email and social networking status updates, then this article is not for you. However, if you would like to benefit from improved battery life, the satisfaction of causing less global warming and maybe some more peace of mind, well then... read on.

The Android Open Source Project (AOSP) is indeed open source, as it is built on the GNU/Linux kernel and the code is freely available online. However, an Android device has plenty of Google bits that are closed source and deeply integrated into the OS. If an Android device maker wants to remove the proprietary Google bits, that firm can no longer be part of the Android Alliance. (Amazon and Yandex have already done this but they added their own closed source bits.) For an ordinary phone user though, it will be quite a greasy pole. But, let us give it a try anyway.

Change Google settings

Most people breeze through the initial Google settings without waiting to read what is shown on the screen. Why? What could go wrong? Essentially, Google says that it will save your Wi-Fi network password on its servers and prevent your phone from ever going to sleep again, ever — whether you are using the phone or not!

Microsoft has made it impossible to turn off data collection in Windows 10, but it does not have to worry about devices (PCs mostly) being connected to mobile data. Android devices have a multitude of connectivity options. Fear of class action suits has prevented Google from performing data collection with mobile data. So, Google provides options to turn these settings off. Well then, turn them off. Google has redefined Airplane Mode. It turns the mobile data (telco) off but Wi-Fi can be turned on.

If you believe in man-made climate change, then it



must also be easy to imagine that each Android smartphone is costing at least one polar bear its icy home. If not, then try to guilt-trip your friends with that idea... just for the fun of it.

Apart from general Google apps settings, there are other settings within each Google app that help to keep tabs on you. For example, the Chrome browser will automatically transmit each Web address that you visit to Google servers, of course, for malware and fraud prevention. Well, I built my own browser. You can, however, use the Firefox for Android app, as it is totally free and open source software (FOSS).

Change the app status

The app settings screen has several columns - *Downloaded*, *Running*, *All* and *Disabled*. Many Google apps as well as manufacturer bloatware hide in the *All* column. Take some time to study or research these apps. If you know what you are doing, you can stop and disable many of them permanently. Be sure not to disable important system apps or anything you might need.

Root to remove unwanted apps

Most device manufacturers install online shopping and social networking apps as system apps. They start automatically, run all the time and waste your battery charge and data connection. In India, they are less afraid of lawsuits and cause data usage whether you are on Wi-Fi or mobile data. Such system apps cannot be disabled. You can get rid of them only by rooting the device. But since rooting voids warranty, remember that it is an option only for the brave.

If the device cannot be rooted, then use a task killer or a startup manager app to disable unwanted apps regularly, on-demand or at startup.

Use alternative apps and app stores

Some Google apps may be decidedly rogue, such as Google